PHL204: Philosophy in Everyday life

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Outline

Second Module

The Question

Bodily Continuity

Psychological Continuity

Topic

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The Question

Bodily Continuity

Psychological Continuity

Personal Identity and Death



In this module we will discuss questions about what changes we can survive, what death means, whether we should fear it, and the ethical issues raised by medically-assisted death

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The question

Can you survive teleportation to Mars?

Identity

Two kinds of identity:

Numerical Identity

A is numerically identical to B if A is the very same object as B

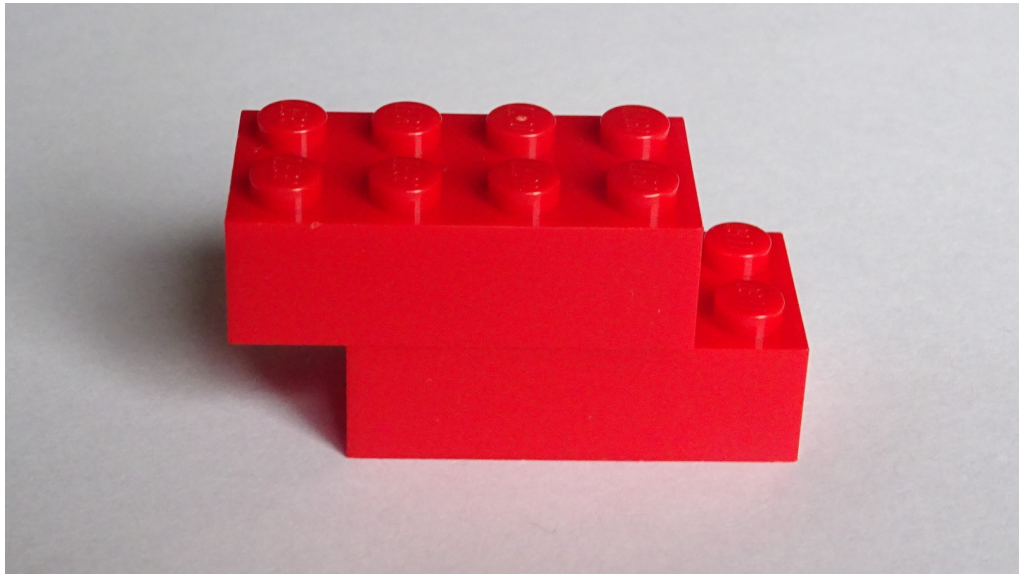
Qualitative Identity

A is qualitatively identical to B if A and B share all and only the same qualitative properties

Identity

The kinds of properties that ensure qualitative identity:

- size
- shape
- color



These lego bricks are qualitatively identical but they are not numerically identical:

- they have all the same qualitative properties, but there are two of them

Personal Identity

The kind of identity we care about, when we talk about personal identity is numerical identity

So what makes it the case that we are the very same person that we were 5 seconds ago, or 5 days ago, or even *5 years ago*?

Personal Identity

Two main options for what makes you the same person over time:

- bodily continuity
- psychological continuity

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You are your body

Perhaps what makes you the same person over time is that you share the same body

But there are some problems with this view

Ship of Theseus



- Imagine the Ship of Theseus is getting old and we start to replace each of its parts (planks, ropes, sails etc) with new parts until every part is replaced

Is this still the Ship of Theseus?

Ship of Theseus



- Now imagine that you take all the old parts and you assemble a new ship using all and only those parts

Which of these two ships is the Ship of Theseus?

Bodily Continuity

A body is just a collection of bodily parts

In general, we don't think we need to have identical bodies to remain the same person

A person could lose a limb, but that doesn't mean they would be a new person

Could a person slowly replace all of their parts and remain the same person?

Bodily Continuity

Imagine a sci-fi scenario in which we do slowly replace every part of your body

We can already replace your vital organs

You will eventually replace your skin cells

Suppose we can slowly transplant your brain as well

Suppose it is possible that we can replace every part eventually (perhaps over a number of years)—is this still you if your body is now made up of completely different body parts?

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Psychological continuity

If we reject bodily continuity, then perhaps we ought go for psychological continuity instead

This is the view that what makes you the same person as you were 5 minutes ago or 5 years ago is that you are psychologically continuous with them

So, it is not having the same body that matters, but having the same psychological profile

This is why it is still you even if we replace all your body parts

You are your psychological profile

What kind of psychological data matters that guarantees we are the same person as we were from 5 years ago?

It can't be an unbroken chain of conscious experience because we go to sleep or may have been placed under general anesthesia

So, stream of consciousness is not enough, what else needs to be added?

Consciousness and memory

Proposal: what makes you the same person as five years ago is that you share a stream of consciousness and have all the memories of the person from five years ago

Problem: what if somebody else was at the same event as you five years ago and remembers it as well, what makes one of these your memory and the other one their memory?

Definition of memory

Typically, we say X is your memory if:

- it is a mental impression of some past event
- which is causally connected to the original event in the right way, and
- *you were there at the event*

So, we cannot define personal identity in terms of memory because we already define memory in terms of personal identity

This would be a circular definition

Memory continuity problems

Other issues we may worry about:

- If you start losing your memories because of dementia, do you stop being the same person?
- Nobody can remember their very first years after birth, does that mean that we are not the same person until we start forming memories?